Written Assignment

Guidelines for the Creation of a Written Assignment

Definition and objective 1
Structure and components of a Written Assignment 1
Formal guidelines and requirements 3
Evaluation 3

DEFINITION AND OBJECTIVE

A written assignment should demonstrate the academic writing capabilities of the student. In this assignment, students are expected to show that they are capable of independently exploring a scientific topic, undertaking the relevant research, and using that research to justify their own thoughts and insights and support them theoretically.

Good academic writing does not simply take any result or theoretical position and assume it to be true. Instead, it seeks to prove or disprove the result or position by supporting or countering it with the use of reliable sources and facts.

STRUCTURE AND COMPONENTS OF A WRITTEN ASSIGNMENT

The structure of the assignment should reflect a logical progression of main points and explanatory points. The text should be a coherent and cohesive whole and follow a linear structure. There should be a logical integration of the main and explanatory points across the various sections, with clear transitions between them. Referring to a key argument in a previous paragraph, for example, can create connections between the points. The main body of the assignment is composed of the core argument (around 80% of the assignment) and is preceded by an introduction (around 10%) and followed by a conclusion (around 10%).

Introduction

The introduction is the first paragraph of an assignment and should be created as an integral part of the text. The introduction should include concise but clear explanations of the following points, which may, if needed, be presented in subsections or under subheadings:

- Rationale for topic selection based on the current state of research on the chosen topic (Why is the topic relevant and what are the open questions to be addressed in the research essay). This is where you should refer to your research question.
- Scope of the topic and necessary definitions (What is beyond the scope of the assignment? What is within range? What should be the scope of the intended outcomes?)
- Aim of the assignment or the research question (What is to be presented/found out and why?)
- Outline of the structure and the arguments within the assignment (What can the reader expect in the main body, and what structure does the assignment follow?)

It makes sense to think about these introductory remarks early on, even if they are written towards the end of the writing process. This will help give your work a stringent and clear line of argumentation that extends throughout all parts of the assignment and leads to a meaningful conclusion.

Main body

This part of academic writing should peak, and maintain, interest through coherent and comprehensible argumentation. This is only possible if the assignment has a common thread that links each key point.

If something is not taken to be common knowledge (such as “the sky is blue”), then it must be explained and backed up with the use of a theoretically or practically reasonable argument. These statements need to be proven with the use of appropriate literary resources. All assumptions, considerations, and arguments must be proven, discussed and confirmed by providing adequate reference sources. Each argument should be as clear and as well structured as possible.

Main points should always be positioned at the beginning of the paragraph, with supporting points clearly connected to it. The structure of individual paragraphs should loosely follow this framework:

- Identify main point(s)
- Main body (methodology, case work and solution)
- Explain, discuss and elaborate main point(s) by using supporting points
- Draw conclusion from the argument (leading to the next point)

Conclusion

The conclusion should give the reader a final, overall impression of the assignment. It should not be a repetition of what was written in the assignment. This is only useful in a longer thesis, for example a master’s thesis. Instead, the conclusion should draw the arguments to a close. It should summarize the key arguments within the assignment, seek to conclude the thesis or main claim and answer any questions that were raised. The conclusion can also include any follow-up questions or perspectives regarding the topic that could be further researched.

The conclusion should not include any new ideas or arguments but rather present a substantive synthesis.

Components of the Written Assignment

The written assignment consists of the following parts, listed in the table of contents (except for title page and table of contents):

- Title page
- Table of contents (structure)
- List of figures and/or tables
- List of abbreviations
- Text part with introduction, main part, conclusion
- Reference list
- List of appendices
- Appendices and materials

Submission

Written assignments are submitted exclusively in digital form via Turnitin in the corresponding myCampus course. The course also contains a submission guide that provides all the important information about submitting your assignment. Please make sure to read this guide carefully before submitting your work.

FORMAL GUIDELINES AND REQUIREMENTS

The following provides an overview of the key formal requirements and additional documents.

Length BACHELOR	7–10 pages of text
Length MASTER	12–15 pages of text
Formalities	Please refer to the Guidelines for Structuring and Formatting Academic Papers at IU International University in myCampus.
Citation standard	Please refer to the citation guidelines in myCampus.
Reference list	Please refer to the citation guidelines in myCampus.
Affidavit	This pledge must be submitted electronically (via myCampus) before you can submit your assignment.

EVALUATION

The evaluation criteria and their corresponding weight are listed below.

Evaluation criteria	Explanation	Weight
Introduction	Introduction and scope of the topic, objectives, research interest and question, description and justification of the approach and process	10%
Structure	Composition and structure, logical structure and appropriate length of the individual sections	15%
Reasoning	Quality of argument and research, convincing and appropriately supported arguments, critical reflection and weighing of the arguments and justification of the pros and cons	40%
Conclusion	Conclusion and recommendations, limitations and possible further research areas (desiderata)	15%
Language/form	Linguistic expression and spelling/punctuation, thoughts/arguments and findings formulated precisely and scientifically (according to academic standards)	10%
Formalities	Adherence to IU guidelines	10%

Good luck with your Written Assignment!